Siddaramaiah. A series of setbacks followed—a sanction from Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot to investigate the CM for an allocation of 14 housing sites that his wife Parvathi B.M. had received in 2021 as compensation for giving up a 3.16-acre parcel of land she owned in Mysuru; a Karnataka High Court order allowing this probe; and an Opposition campaign demanding the CM's resignation. What followed was a perception of drift, officials and partymen admit, as Siddaramaiah, who has seldom come under direct attack, trained his energies on trying to fight back what he claims is a political tactic to unseat him. "What is my role? It is only politically motivated...the BJP and JD(S) are making an issue out of a non-issue," he told INDIA TODAY on December 6 (*see interview*).

BESIDES FOCUSING ON BENGALURU'S DEVELOPMENT, THE GOVERNMENT MUST BOOST REVENUE TO FUND THE STATE'S INFRASTRUCTURE PROJECTS



Photographs: PTI

It was against this backdrop of a MUDA investigation by the Lokayukta looming over him that the bypoll results brought cheer to Siddaramaiah. While the Congress bagged all three constituencies—Channapatna, Shiggaon and Sandur—the aftermath left the Opposition in disarray. The BJP, which had so far put up a semblance of unity, found its internal rumblings spilling into the open with a faction fight led by a group of partymen hostile to state BJP chief B.Y. Vijayendra. Even when the party was agitating for Waqf Act reforms, claiming that land belonging to farmers and religious institutions was under threat, the discord was evident, with both sides planning separate protests on the same issue. In the JD(S), the loss of Channapatna in the Vokkaliga heartland brought back concerns of the regional party's vulnerability which it had temporarily tided over by H.D. Kumaraswamy's induction as Union minister in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's cabinet. Therefore, at Hassan, chosen specifically for its affinity to JD(S) supremo H.D. Deve Gowda, both Siddaramaiah and his deputy D.K. Shivakumar—who has a running feud with the Gowdas—trained their guns on the JD(S) first family.

CRITICAL HARMONY

Amidst this show of strength, an equally significant factor was the subtle dynamics between the CM and deputy CM. In fact, the Hassan rally was originally conceived by Siddaramaiah's supporters as a tribute, before the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee, headed by Shivakumar, decided to convert it into a party-organised convention called 'Jana Kalyana Samavesha'. This delicate balance has remained at the heart of Siddaramaiah's second term where, unlike earlier, he has had to cede some space to a deputy CM—an